avoiding talking to the press completely for the best part of a year. That wasn't just a way of getting my own back for what was being said and written about me. I knew I was being watched like never before, and I didn't want to get into a situation where I might say something I'd later regret.

Even before I got off the plane after my time in the States, I got my own sense of what my family had been put through while I was away. The Chief Steward on the flight back to London came over to my seat an hour ahead of us landing at Heathrow.

'When we disembark, there'll be police waiting for you at the gate.'

I thought he was joking. *What were the police there for? To arrest me? To protect me?* Either way, this was going a bit far, wasn't it? Sure enough, there were half a dozen uniformed officers waiting to meet me. We walked through the terminal in a little cluster: me in the middle, them all around me. It was all I could do not to laugh out loud. *What was all this about?* I got my answer soon enough. When we came out through the arrivals area, a wave of camera crews, photographers and journalists broke towards us, shouting out for pictures, for me to say something, for any kind of reaction at all. The policemen just bundled me across the hall and into the back of the car that was waiting to pick me up. It was terrifying. And it was just the start.

A couple of days later, I was back at Old Trafford for pre-season training. For a few hours every day, at least, I could just concentrate on soccer and shut everything else out of my mind. There was a bit of light-hearted banter in the dressing room but my team-mates knew I was struggling with what was happening and, in that situation, players will always support each other. And I was happy being back with them and playing again. The distraction helped me put on a brave face for Mum and Dad, who were being put through it enough without having to see me really upset about things as well. They'd been advised by the police to come up to Manchester because it wasn't safe for me to be on my own in the house in Worsley. Dad used to drive me into training at the Cliff and then pick me up again after work. I wouldn't have asked them. In fact I offered to send them off on vacation for a break from it all. But I think my parents felt easier being there with me.

I think it might be hard for people to understand what it was like living my life in those first months after the World Cup. It was difficult enough for my friends to imagine it until they experienced it first hand. A couple of days after I got back from America, Dave Gardner and I met up after training to go and have some lunch in Manchester city center. We went to a place we knew